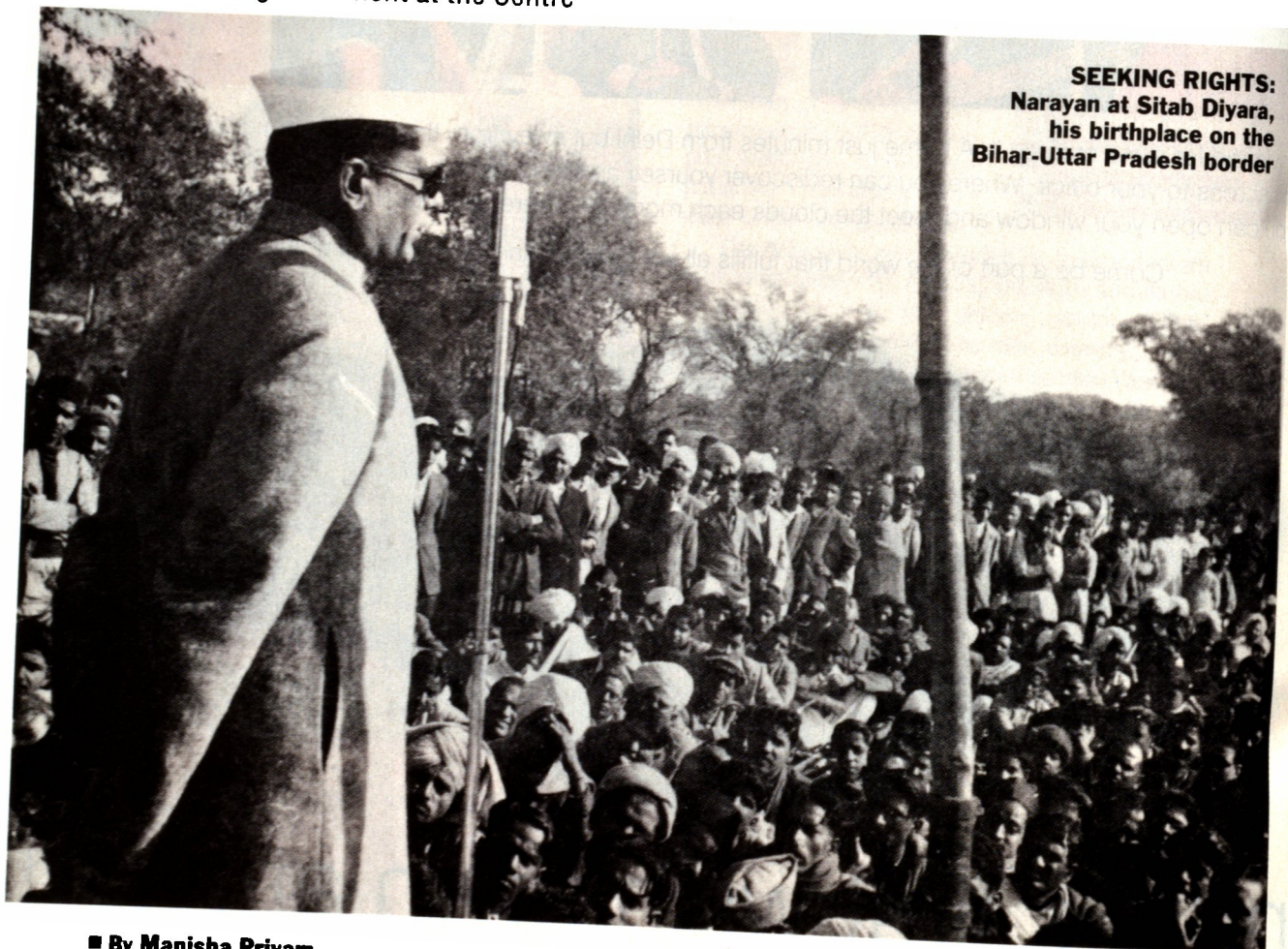


J P MOVEMENT

Churning POINT

India's first mass agitation after Independence fired the imagination of the common man and shook the government at the Centre



SEEKING RIGHTS:
Narayan at Sitab Diyara,
his birthplace on the
Bihar-Uttar Pradesh border

■ By Manisha Priyam

It was the largest people's movement in independent India, one that shook Indira Gandhi's government, churned out a new generation of leaders and tried to instill probity in political life. Jayaprakash Narayan, a charming and fiery leader, part of India's struggle for Independence, started the "JP Movement" in 1974 against the authoritarian rule of the Congress, led by Indira Gandhi. He spearheaded this campaign at the fag end of his long political career and it represents a maturation of his political thinking and action. It was during this movement that he realised what Ram Manohar Lohia thought was his true potential—"JP can move

the nation, provided the mover does not vacillate". His role as the leader of the movement earned him the title of Loknayak—People's Leader.

The movement provided the people an important channel through which they could express their resentment over many issues—rising prices, unemployment, food scarcity and corruption. Political dissent, public anger, the energy of the youth, and a vision for a society built on lokniti (peoples' participation), rather than rajniti (political power) powered the movement. Narayan brought together these diverse sentiments and differing political positions into a mass movement that was